

CHAPTER THREE

Everyone Makes Mistakes

This is the chapter where Marcus knocks over a block tower.

The block tower belonged to Jaylen, who was in another first-grade class down the hall but who sometimes came to Room 12 for choice time on Fridays. Jaylen had been working on the tower for fifteen minutes, which is a very long time when you are six. The tower was almost as tall as Jaylen.

Marcus came over to see it. Marcus is a child who has trouble standing still when something interesting is happening. He did not mean to bump the block table. He did not even know, until it was too late, that his hip had touched the corner of it.

The tower fell.

It fell in the slow, terrible way that block towers always fall — first the top, then the middle, then a long pause, and then the whole bottom letting go all at once, in a sound that is louder than fifteen blocks should be able to make.

Jaylen stared at the blocks.

Marcus stared at the blocks too.

Then Marcus said the thing he always said, which was the thing that came out of his mouth before his brain had time to put on its shoes: "I am SO CLUMSY. I always break things. I am the WORST at blocks." Jaylen did not say anything. He was about to cry, but he had not started yet.

Ms. Calloway, who had been across the room, came over without hurrying. She has a way of arriving in a situation that does not make the situation bigger. Sammy was on her hand, which surprised Marcus a little, because Sammy did not usually come out during choice time. "Marcus," said Sammy, "I heard you say something just now."

Marcus looked at Sammy. He was almost in tears.

"I said I always break things," said Marcus. "I am clumsy."

"You said two different things," said Sammy. "You said I always break things. And you said I am clumsy. Those are two different things. The first one is about what happened. The second one is about who you are. Those are not the same."

Marcus blinked.

Sammy turned, very gently, to look at the blocks.

"Here is what is true," said Sammy. "You bumped a table. That is true. The tower fell down. That is true. Jaylen is sad about it. That is true. Those are true things. But I always break things is not true. You do not always break things. You broke this. That is different."

Marcus said, in a small voice, "But I did break it."

"You did," said Sammy. "And now there are three things you can do, in order. The Three Things are: Oops. Then Fix It. Then Try Again." The class was quiet. Even the kids who had not been near the blocks were listening now, because Sammy's voice carries in a room. "Oops," said Sammy, "is the part where you say: I made a mistake. I am sorry it happened. I am sorry it hurt someone."

"Fix It," said Sammy, "is the part where you ask: what can I do to help? In this case — would you like to help Jaylen rebuild the tower?" "Try Again," said Sammy, "is the part where, next time you walk past a block tower, you remember to walk slower."

Marcus looked at Jaylen.

"Sorry I knocked your tower down," he said. "I did not mean to. Do you want help fixing it?"

Jaylen, who had still not cried, said, "Yes."

So Marcus and Jaylen got down on the floor of Room 12 on a Friday morning in September, and they rebuilt the tower together. The new tower was a little bit different. The new tower had a wider base. Jaylen pointed at the wider base and said, "If somebody bumps it now, it will not fall."

Marcus said, "That is a good idea."

They built the tower until the bell rang.

Now — here is something the kids in Room 12 did not know at the time, but which we know, because we are reading a book about them. What Marcus had almost done — what almost happened, in that first moment, before Sammy showed up — was a thing that grown-ups do all their lives without knowing it. Marcus had almost taken one thing that happened and turned it into who he is. He had almost said I am clumsy and I always break things, as if one bumped table proved a forever-truth about Marcus.

It does not prove a forever-truth. One bumped table proves that one table got bumped. That is all it proves.

Some kids learn this when they are six. Most adults learn it when they are forty. The kids who learn it when they are six get a head start on a kind of peace that takes most people a very long time to find. This is one of the small, secret reasons Room 12 matters. The kids do not know they are getting the head start. But they are.